

Simple tenses

THE TENSE OF A VERB INDICATES WHEN AN ACTION TAKES PLACE.

Unlike most parts of speech, verbs change their form. These different forms, known as tenses, indicate the timing of an action, which is performed by the first, second, or third person.

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Picking the right person

Each verb must express a person (first, second, or third), a number (singular or plural), and a tense (past, present, or future). There are three persons in English. These identify who is taking part in a conversation.

The word *tense* comes from the Latin word *tempus*, which means “time.”

▷ The first person

The first person represents the speaker, and uses the personal pronouns *I* or *me* if the speaker is alone, and *we* or *us* if the speaker is accompanied.



▷ The second person

The second person addresses the reader or listener, and uses *you* for both singular and plural.



▷ The third person

The third person represents everyone and everything else, and uses the singular pronouns *he* and *him*, *she* and *her*, and *it*, and the plural pronouns *they* and *them*.

